2012–13, there were 1,434 applications.[2] East Jerusalemites have not suddenly grown fond of the Israeli government, but citizenship feels permanent in a way that residency does not. The Israeli passport carries benefits, such as visa-free travel to the European Union, and a full franchise. There is also is a growing sense that the conflict will not end anytime soon.

Israel insists that it looks after Jerusalemites in all parts of the city, regardless of ethnicity or nationality. “Compare the quality of life of the Arab residents in Jerusalem to the quality of life in the region, in Gaza, in Lebanon, in Syria, in Iraq, and people understand, here in our city we care about them,” said the mayor, Nir Barkat.

And indeed, compared to Raqqa, the capital of the Islamic State’s self-proclaimed “caliphate,” the residents of East Jerusalem are well off. But compared to Rehavia in the west, they are not. Schools in East Jerusalem have a shortage of 1,000 classrooms. One-third of households are not connected to the municipal water grid. Basic services, from hospitals to post offices, are woefully scarce, and most residents live below the poverty line. A 2013 United Nations study found that 40 per cent of the men were unemployed, and nearly twice as many women. Those with jobs mostly toil in construction, agriculture and the service industry.[3]

Around the time of Shalloudi’s attack the city did try to fix one disparity: it started enforcing the finer points of municipal law. The protests that followed Abu Khdair’s murder in July had never fully stopped, so the Palestinian districts in East Jerusalem were being targeted for punishment. A resident of the Old City was ordered to remove his home’s water heater, because it was installed without permission; another man, from Beit Hanina, had his car towed because he was two payments behind on his *arnona*, a bi-monthly municipal tax. “I don’t think they do this in Talpiot,” he said, referring to a Jewish neighborhood in the west. In Shuafat, police handed out dozens of $130 fines for parking on the curb, a virtual necessity in a neighborhood with narrow streets and few parking lots.

Barkat denied that the crackdown was targeted at Palestinians, insisting that the law is applied equally. “The mayor has a clear policy of enforcing the law in all parts of Jerusalem,” said his spokeswoman, Brachie Sprung. “People who live in West Jerusalem pay for things they do illegally, and the same applies in the east.”